Who Is Thinking? Artificial Intelligence, Authorship, and the Purpose of Philosophy

Abstract. The arrival of generative artificial intelligence confronts philosophy with a case that its practices were never designed to handle: an argument whose key formulations first appeared in an AI's responses, yet which the human author understands, defends, and develops further. Current debate treats this as a choice between two conceptions of philosophy—truth-seeking, on which only the quality of arguments matters, and human achievement, on which personally producing an argument has intrinsic value. I argue that neither conception yields a workable standard for AI-assisted philosophy. Drawing on Peirce and Popper, Kant, the Socratic distinction between possessing words and possessing understanding, and recent work on extended and "midtended" cognition, I develop a third criterion: *epistemic agency*—whether the human thinker understands, evaluates, controls, and can take responsibility for the ideas produced in human–AI interaction. The relevant distinction is not between using and not using AI but between cognitive substitution and cognitive augmentation. I defend the resulting view against three objections, and argue that generative AI breaks the identification of two functions of the philosophical paper—advancing inquiry and certifying individual ability—which institutions must now disentangle.

Keywords: epistemic agency · generative artificial intelligence · authorship · extended mind · cognitive offloading · metaphilosophy

1. Introduction

The arrival of generative artificial intelligence presents philosophy with a peculiar problem. Suppose a philosopher begins with a vague idea, discusses it extensively with an AI system, receives objections and counterarguments, revises the thesis, asks the AI to improve the structure and language, and eventually produces an excellent philosophical essay. The human understands the resulting argument, can defend it against objections, can identify its weaknesses, and can continue developing it in new directions. Yet many of the important formulations—and perhaps even some of the arguments—first appeared in the AI's responses. Who wrote the essay?

One tempting answer is simple: the human did not. If the important intellectual work was generated by an AI, claiming the result as one's own seems like a form of self-deception. The opposite answer is equally tempting: why should the biological origin of each idea matter? If the resulting argument is sound, the human genuinely understands it, and the work advances philosophical inquiry, perhaps the provenance of each sentence is secondary.

The disagreement reveals a deeper conflict over the purpose of philosophy itself. Is philosophy primarily a *truth-seeking activity*, in which the quality of arguments and conclusions matters most? Or is philosophy also a form of *human intellectual achievement*, in which the process of personally producing an argument has intrinsic value? Generative AI makes it increasingly difficult to avoid choosing between these conceptions.

I will argue that both capture something important but that neither is sufficient. The most useful criterion for AI-assisted philosophy is neither whether every idea originated in the human mind

nor whether the final product is simply good. What matters is *epistemic agency*: whether the human thinker understands, evaluates, controls, accepts responsibility for, and can further develop the ideas produced through the human–AI interaction. AI therefore forces us to move from a binary conception of authorship toward a theory of distributed intellectual agency.

The argument proceeds in four movements. Sections 2 and 3 develop the two rival conceptions—philosophy as truth-seeking and philosophy as human achievement—and show that each captures something the other misses. Sections 4 through 6 test the middle ground between them, using the Socratic distinction between possessing words and possessing understanding, the recent concept of generative midtended cognition, and the literature on cognitive extraction and offloading; the outcome is a distinction between cognitive substitution and cognitive augmentation. Sections 7 through 9 draw the consequences for authorship, for the institution of the philosophical paper, and for the criterion of legitimate authorship itself. Section 10 answers three objections, and section 11 concludes.

2. Philosophy as Truth-Seeking

One influential conception of philosophy treats it as a collective attempt to improve our beliefs through reason, criticism, and inquiry. On this view, the source of an argument is less important than whether it survives examination.

The American pragmatist Charles Sanders Peirce provides an important precedent. Peirce rejected an excessively individualistic conception of knowledge: inquiry is conducted by communities across time, and truth is connected to what inquiry would ultimately converge upon under sufficiently good conditions (Peirce 1931–1958, 5.407). Knowledge is therefore not simply the private achievement of an isolated thinker.

Karl Popper radicalized a related idea in his philosophy of science. For Popper, intellectual progress occurs through bold conjectures followed by severe criticism. There is no reliable logical method for generating good hypotheses; an idea may originate in intuition, accident, myth, or imagination (Popper 1963). What matters intellectually is what happens afterward: can the conjecture withstand attempts to refute it? The objectivity of science lives not in the biography of its hypotheses but in the public practice of criticizing them.

Generative AI fits remarkably well into this conception of philosophy. An AI may generate twenty possible objections to an argument in seconds. It may expose an ambiguity that the philosopher failed to notice, or propose an alternative distinction that would have taken weeks of reading to discover independently. If philosophy is fundamentally concerned with improving arguments, refusing such assistance merely because its source is artificial begins to look arbitrary.

Andy Clark has pushed this point further. On the extended mind thesis, human beings have always constructed hybrid cognitive systems out of notebooks, diagrams, language, calculators, and other external resources; cognition was never confined neatly inside the skull (Clark and Chalmers 1998). Clark now argues that generative AI represents a dramatic expansion of this standing tendency rather than an alien intrusion into cognition (Clark 2025). From this perspective, the complaint that “AI thought of it, not you” assumes exactly what needs to be demonstrated: that genuine human cognition must consist only of operations performed internally by the unaided biological brain.

Consider an engineer designing a complex aircraft. The engineer does not personally calculate every stress distribution, manufacture every component, or write every line of software. Computer simulations, specialist teams, databases, and automated tools contribute to the design. Nevertheless, we may reasonably say that the engineer designed the system, because the engineer understands the architecture, evaluates alternatives, makes the crucial decisions, and takes responsibility for the outcome. Why should philosophy operate under a radically different conception of intellectual agency?

3. Philosophy as Human Achievement

There is, however, something missing from the purely truth-seeking account.

Suppose two students submit exactly the same brilliant argument. The first spent months developing it independently. The second typed a question into an AI system, received the complete argument, verified that it made sense, and submitted it unchanged. Even if the papers are identical, most of us would hesitate to say that the students demonstrated identical philosophical ability.

This suggests that philosophical writing performs at least two functions. It produces intellectual objects that can be evaluated for truth, validity, originality, and usefulness. But it also *demonstrates* something about the thinker who produced them.

Immanuel Kant provides the clearest classical basis for this second conception. In "An Answer to the Question: What Is Enlightenment?" Kant characterizes enlightenment through the demand that individuals dare to use their *own* understanding—the motto *sapere aude* (Kant 1784). The problem is not merely possessing false beliefs. It is remaining intellectually dependent upon others who think on one's behalf.

Generative AI makes Kant's concern unexpectedly contemporary. An AI system may become the ultimate intellectual guardian: always available, enormously informed, articulate, patient, and increasingly capable of reasoning through difficult problems. One may eventually have little practical need to think without it. From a Kantian perspective, receiving the correct conclusion is not enough; rational autonomy itself has value.

This explains a strange psychological response that AI provokes even among accomplished intellectuals. Imagine a philosopher who discovers that an AI can immediately locate weaknesses in arguments that took months to develop. The philosopher might feel intellectually diminished even though the resulting philosophy improves. From the standpoint of truth-seeking, this reaction seems irrational: criticism has become more effective, so philosophy is progressing. From the standpoint of intellectual achievement, however, the reaction makes perfect sense. What the philosopher valued was not merely possessing better arguments but *being capable of producing them*.

Chess shows the same structure. Chess engines have long played far better chess than any human, yet human chess did not disappear. If the purpose of the game were solely to identify the objectively strongest move, humans would simply consult computers. Instead, competitive chess deliberately excludes engine assistance, because the activity measures human intellectual achievement. The same distinction may apply to philosophy.

4. Possessing Words and Understanding Them

Yet intellectual achievement cannot simply mean generating everything oneself.

Socrates offers a more subtle criterion. Throughout Plato's dialogues, Socrates repeatedly distinguishes between possessing words and possessing understanding. Someone may confidently state the correct doctrine yet collapse when questioned about its implications.

The point becomes especially sharp in the *Phaedrus*, where Socrates criticizes writing itself: written words can give the appearance of wisdom without the reality, and a written text always says the same thing, unable to defend itself when questioned (Plato 1995, 274c–277a).

Generative AI partially reverses this ancient problem. Unlike a book, an AI can respond: it can defend an argument, revise it, answer objections, and generate examples. But Socrates' challenge can now be redirected toward the human user. Suppose an AI produces a sophisticated argument about personal identity. The relevant Socratic question is not "Did you type every sentence?" but "Do you know what these sentences mean?"

Can the human explain why the third premise is necessary? Can she identify circumstances under which the conclusion would fail? Can the argument be reformulated when a counterexample is introduced? Can she distinguish the strong version of the thesis from the weak one?

If not, the human possesses philosophical text without philosophical understanding, and the Socratic accusation stands. If so, however, the accusation that "the AI wrote it, therefore it is not yours in any philosophically meaningful sense" loses its force. What matters is not the typing but the understanding.

5. From Extended Minds to Generative Midtended Cognition

Recent philosophy of AI is beginning to describe this intermediate territory more precisely.

Xabier Barandiarán and Marta Pérez-Verdugo propose the concept of *generative midtended cognition* (Barandiarán and Pérez-Verdugo 2025). Generative AI can introduce material that was not fully intended in advance by the human, yet the human can subsequently evaluate, appropriate, reshape, and incorporate that contribution into an intentional cognitive process. The resulting thought is therefore not straightforwardly internally generated, but neither is it simply an alien product passively received from outside.

This resembles ordinary intellectual life more than we may initially admit. A philosopher discusses an unfinished argument with a colleague. The colleague says, "Perhaps your real distinction is not between freedom and determinism, but between control and authorship." The philosopher suddenly recognizes that this formulation clarifies the entire problem. Who thought of the distinction?

Obviously, the colleague produced the sentence first. Yet after months of development, the distinction may become deeply integrated into the philosopher's own theoretical framework, and we would ordinarily not conclude that every subsequent use of it remains permanently external to her thought. Authorship of an idea can be acquired through appropriation.

AI complicates this familiar process because it can generate intellectual contributions on an enormous scale. But the scale changes the situation in degree, not in kind. The important question therefore becomes not simply *where an idea first appeared*, but *what happened after it appeared*.

6. Cognitive Extraction: Substitution versus Augmentation

An overly optimistic account nevertheless faces an important objection, stronger than the simple claim that using AI is intellectually dishonest.

Louis Loock has argued that intelligent technologies may not merely extend cognition but *extract* it—a direct counter to the extended mind thesis. A tool that repeatedly performs a task may gradually reduce the user's ability to perform that task independently; where Clark and Chalmers see the mind spreading into its tools, Loock sees the tools siphoning capacities out of their users (Loock 2025).

Jeffrey Maynes develops a related concern about generative AI and cognitive offloading, warning of a possible critical-thinking "death spiral": increased dependence on AI weakens critical-thinking ability, and weakened critical-thinking ability makes users less capable of judging when AI should or should not be trusted, producing still greater dependence (Maynes 2026). Recent empirical work points in the same direction, reporting associations between heavier AI-tool use, increased cognitive offloading, and reduced critical-thinking performance (Gerlich 2025).

The force of this objection is that it predicts genuine cognitive loss, not mere impurity of method. Consider two philosophers who use AI extensively. The first asks AI to produce complete arguments and gradually loses the ability to construct or evaluate them independently. The second uses AI aggressively to generate objections, alternative formulations, counterexamples, and competing theoretical frameworks; she rejects most suggestions, interrogates the remainder, and becomes increasingly skilled at recognizing weaknesses in arguments. Both have "used AI," but philosophically their situations are almost opposites. The first has substituted AI cognition for human cognition. The second has used AI to intensify human cognition.

The relevant distinction therefore cannot be between AI use and non-use. It must be between *cognitive substitution* and *cognitive augmentation*. And the dividing line runs through precisely the territory marked out in the previous section: augmentation occurs when the human evaluates, appropriates, and reshapes what the AI supplies; substitution occurs when she does not.

7. Authorship and Responsibility

A further complication concerns authorship itself.

René van Woudenberg, Chris Ranalli, and Daniel Bracker argue that current systems such as ChatGPT should not straightforwardly be regarded as authors. Authorship involves more than generating sequences of words: authors normally possess intentions and beliefs, make assertions, and can be held responsible for what they say, and current language models do not obviously participate in these normative practices in the relevant way (van Woudenberg, Ranalli, and Bracker 2024).

But denying that AI is an author does not automatically establish that the human user is the sole author. An intermediate possibility emerges: authorship itself may become distributed or graded. This is already common outside AI. Research papers have multiple authors; films distinguish directors, writers, editors, and producers; software projects distinguish original authors from contributors. Intellectual work has never always needed a single source, and generative AI may force philosophical writing to acknowledge this complexity openly.

What matters most, however, is responsibility. If a human presents an argument as one she endorses, she should be prepared to answer for it. "The AI said so" cannot function as an intellectual defense. This yields a principle that will do most of the remaining work:

> **The Epistemic Responsibility Principle.** A person may legitimately claim an AI-assisted argument as her own only to the extent that she is willing and able to assume epistemic responsibility for it—that is, to understand it, evaluate it, defend it, and answer for its assertion.

Understanding is therefore necessary but not sufficient. The thinker must also exercise judgment: the responsibility assumed must be responsibility for a case she has actually examined.

8. The Crisis of the Philosophy Paper

This analysis leads to a larger institutional problem.

Academic philosophy papers have historically performed two functions simultaneously. First, they contribute propositions and arguments to collective inquiry; call this *epistemic certification*. Second, they demonstrate that a particular scholar possesses certain intellectual abilities; call this *achievement certification*.

Before generative AI, these functions were imperfectly but reasonably connected. If someone produced an excellent original paper, it was usually safe to infer that the person possessed substantial philosophical skill. AI breaks that inference: a paper may contain an extraordinary argument while telling us relatively little about which intellectual operations were performed by the named author.

This creates a genuine crisis for academic publishing—but not necessarily because AI will destroy philosophical knowledge. The opposite could occur: arguments may become more rigorous, objections more comprehensive, literature reviews more complete, and prose clearer. What AI threatens is the use of the philosophical paper as a *measurement instrument for individual human ability*.

That distinction matters, because different institutions use papers for different purposes. Hiring committees, examiners, and tenure boards need achievement certification; a journal interested only in advancing knowledge might rationally welcome highly effective human–AI collaborations. The mistake is expecting the same artifact—the philosophy paper—to continue performing both functions under conditions where they have come apart.

9. Epistemic Agency as the Standard

We therefore need a better standard for intellectual authorship in the age of generative AI.

The traditional standard might be called the *origin criterion*: an intellectual work is mine because its ideas originated primarily in my own mind. At the other extreme lies a pure *product criterion*: it does not matter who produced the ideas, only the quality of the final argument. Neither is satisfactory.

The origin criterion ignores the deeply social and technologically mediated nature of human cognition. Philosophers have always thought through books, conversations, criticism, and notation; the demand that every valuable thought originate spontaneously inside a biological brain has never described actual philosophical practice (Clark and Chalmers 1998). The product criterion ignores intellectual autonomy, responsibility, and the cultivation of philosophical ability; it cannot explain why the two identical student essays feel so different, nor why accomplished philosophers feel diminished rather than merely supplied.

A better criterion is *epistemic agency*. I exercise epistemic agency over an argument when I can understand it, evaluate it, decide whether to endorse it, identify its weaknesses, respond to objections, modify it when necessary, connect it to my other commitments, and take responsibility for asserting it. The Epistemic Responsibility Principle of section 7 states the practical upshot: legitimate authorship tracks responsibility assumed, and responsibility presupposes agency exercised.

Under this model, asking whether "I" or "AI" wrote a philosophy paper increasingly resembles asking whether a modern aircraft was designed by the engineer or by the computers. The better answer is: the relevant cognitive system included both, but responsibility and control were distributed asymmetrically. The human remains philosophically significant not because every valuable thought must originate inside a biological brain, but because the human can occupy the position of reflective judgment within the larger system.

10. Three Objections

10.1 Understanding after the fact is still not doing the work

A student can study an AI-produced argument until she can defend it in examination. By the agency criterion she now counts as a legitimate author, yet she still did not *have* the idea. Does the criterion not launder cheating into authorship?

It does not, because the criterion legitimizes endorsement, not discovery. The Epistemic Responsibility Principle governs when it is honest to claim and assert an argument; it was never meant to certify that the author possesses the skills that unaided production would have demonstrated. Section 8's distinction is designed precisely to keep these apart: the student's essay can be epistemically certified (the argument is good and understood) while failing to certify her individual ability. What the process of interrogation does change—as the midtended-cognition case showed—is that persistent appropriation can transform alien material into one's own theorizing, as it does when a philosopher absorbs a colleague's chance remark into her framework. Where appropriation ends and laundering begins is a matter of degree, and the gradedness is a feature, not a bug: it makes authorship accountable to examination rather than settled by a single fact about origins.

10.2 The criterion is both too permissive and too demanding

If agency suffices for authorship, then a credulous reader who "understands and endorses" a bad argument also qualifies; if responsibility requires the ability to answer any possible objection, no human author qualifies.

Both horns fail. Agency is not a threshold but a graded achievement that tracks the actual defensibility of the work: endorsing an indefensible argument manifests failed evaluation, not epistemic agency. And responsibility does not require answerability to every conceivable objection—only to the objections a competent peer would raise and to the ones the author actually encounters. The criterion is normative: it tells users what to aim at, and it tells evaluators what to ask for—evidence of agency, of the kind section 4's Socratic questions specify.

10.3 Does this essay meet its own standard?

This essay was itself prepared with the assistance of AI. By its own lights, is it philosophy or a manufactured artifact?

The essay must stand or fall under the criterion it proposes. That is not a dilemma for the view but its application: the question is whether the human author understands, endorses, and can answer for the argument; whether it survives interrogation independently of its provenance; and whether responsibility for its claims is genuinely assumed rather than outsourced. Readers should apply exactly this test to what follows. The essay is therefore also a proposal about disclosure norms: what matters for the future of philosophical writing is not the absence of AI assistance but the presence of an accountable author.

11. Conclusion

Generative AI has revealed an ambiguity that philosophy could previously afford to ignore. We have treated philosophical truth, philosophical authorship, and philosophical ability as though they were naturally united. Usually they were: the person whose name appeared on an essay normally produced its arguments, understood them, defended them, and received credit for the intellectual achievement.

That unity is breaking apart. AI can generate an argument without understanding it in the ordinary human sense. A human can understand an argument without having generated it. A human–AI system can produce an argument that neither would have produced independently.

The philosophical response should be neither to defend an increasingly artificial boundary between "my unaided thought" and external cognition, nor to conclude that authorship and intellectual achievement cease to matter as long as the final text is good. Instead, we should ask a harder question: *who exercises epistemic agency over the argument?*

If a person merely copies an AI-generated essay that she cannot defend, the philosophical achievement is minimal even if the essay is excellent. If she understands the essay but passively accepts the machine's reasoning, the situation improves but remains intellectually limited. If she interrogates the AI, rejects its weak arguments, appropriates useful ideas, restructures them into a coherent position, assumes responsibility for the result, and can continue the inquiry beyond

what the AI originally supplied, then describing the activity as merely “the AI wrote it” becomes inadequate.

Artificial intelligence may eventually surpass humans at producing philosophical arguments. If that occurs, philosophy will face the same realization that chess faced after the arrival of superhuman engines: producing the objectively strongest move and demonstrating human intellectual excellence are different activities. But philosophy has an additional possibility. Unlike competitive chess, philosophy is ultimately interested in understanding, and AI can therefore become not merely an opponent that defeats human thinkers but a cognitive partner through which human understanding develops.

The important boundary in future philosophy will not be between thinking *with* AI and thinking *without* AI. It will be between using AI in ways that enlarge our capacity to think and using AI in ways that make thinking unnecessary.

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